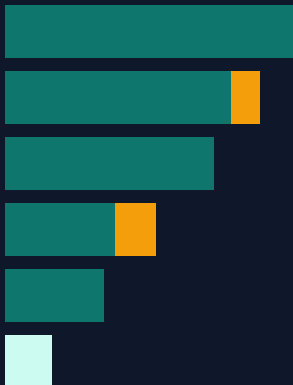


# The D2C Revenue Leak Map

*Where your store actually loses money — and the order to  
fix it in*



For founders running their own D2C brand. Benchmarks from Baymard, Contentsquare, Klaviyo, Uncommerce and Shopify — 99 billion sessions and 410 million Indian shipments. Every number traced. Nothing here claims a client result.

# You do not have a traffic problem

**69.9%**

of all traffic is mobile — and  
desktop converts 74% higher

**70.22%**

of carts are abandoned, averaged  
across 50 studies

**11**

specific leaks between the ad click  
and the second purchase

Most founders answer a flat month the same way: buy more traffic. But look at what happens to the traffic that already arrived. Across 99 billion sessions on 6,000+ sites, the money is not missing at the top — it is leaking at eleven specific points on the way down.

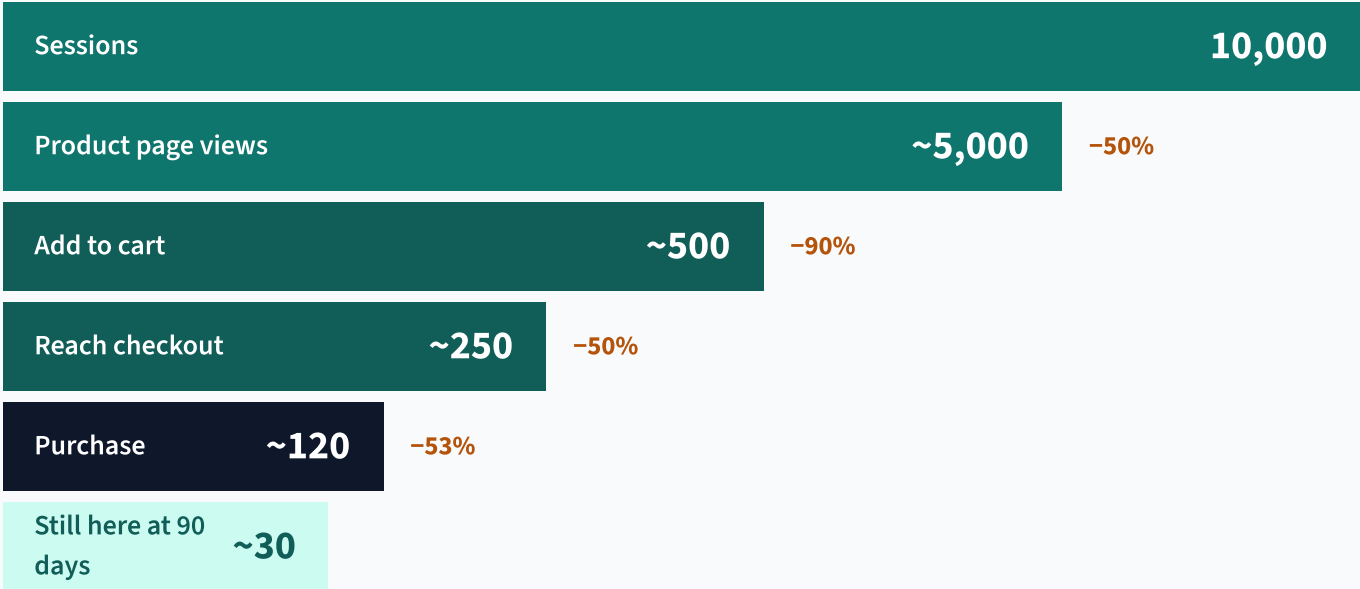
This book maps those eleven points in order. For each one: the benchmark, the diagnosis, the fix. Work top to bottom. Fixing a leak at step 9 while step 3 is still open just moves the loss around.

## HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. Open your analytics next to it.
2. Write your own number beside each benchmark.
3. Fix the first leak where your number is worse than the benchmark. Only that one. Then re-measure.

# The leak map

Take 10,000 sessions on a store converting at a typical rate. Watch where they go.



Ten thousand visits. Roughly 120 orders. Around 30 people who ever come back. Every percentage point in that middle column is worth more than the same point of extra traffic — because you already paid for the traffic.

Traffic is rented. Conversion is owned.

# Your scoreboard

Write down where you stand before you change anything. If you cannot fill a row, that gap is itself a finding — you are flying without the instrument.

| Metric                    | Benchmark to beat                                       | Yours |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| Conversion rate           | Shopify average 1.4%; top 20% 3.2%                      |       |
| Mobile vs desktop CVR     | Desktop runs ~74% higher — wider means mobile is broken |       |
| Add-to-cart rate          | Reported 4–8%. Below 5% = product page problem          |       |
| Cart abandonment          | 70.22% is the average, not a target                     |       |
| Checkout completion       | ~47% reported                                           |       |
| New vs returning CVR      | 1.7% vs 2.9%                                            |       |
| RTO / undelivered         | Indian brands ranged 21–39% in FY26                     |       |
| Repeat purchase rate      | Reported 19–30%                                         |       |
| Email + SMS revenue share | Mature programs report 25–40%                           |       |

Three of those rows will be embarrassing. Those three are this quarter's roadmap.

# 8.4%

A **0.1 second** improvement in load time was measured to lift retail conversions by 8.4%.

Google × Deloitte, Milliseconds Make Millions, 2020

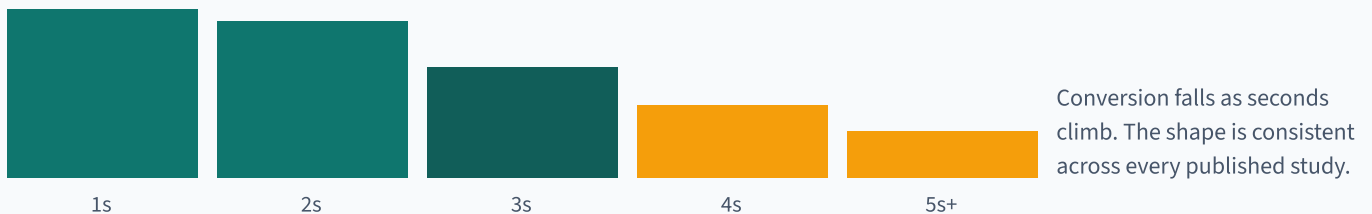
And only about a third of sites pass all three Core Web Vitals, with Largest Contentful Paint the most common failure. Speed is not a technical vanity metric — it is the first filter a paid click passes through. You pay for the click whether or not the page renders.

#### WHERE SECONDS GO

- Hero images at print resolution
- Five apps loading on every page to serve one feature on one page
- Review, chat and pop-up scripts firing before the product image
- Sliders and video backgrounds above the fold
- Custom fonts loading before any text is visible

#### THE FIX, IN ORDER

1. Measure the **product page** and **cart page** on a real 4G phone — not office WiFi on desktop
2. Compress and correctly size every above-the-fold image
3. Audit installed apps. Remove anything whose revenue you cannot name
4. Delay chat, review and pop-up scripts until after first interaction
5. Re-measure. Write the before/after number down



# Structure, not decoration

# 75%

of mobile ecommerce sites rate only “Mediocre” on usability — and those are the big sites with UX budgets.

Baymard Mobile UX Benchmark 2026, 71,000+ elements reviewed

A beautiful store and a usable store are different products. Founders review their site the way a designer does — full screen, desktop, homepage. Customers meet it the way a shopper does: one thumb, a phone, landing straight on a product page.

## STEAL THE STRUCTURE, NOT THE STYLING

- The product image block is the largest element on the page, scrolling through angles, scale shots and detail shots.
- Price, variant, delivery date and buy button are all visible without scrolling.
- Reviews are summarised as a number near the title; full reviews further down.
- Returns and delivery promise stated *on the product page*, not hidden in a footer link.
- Related products appear after the decision content, not before it.
- Search is prominent, forgiving of typos, and returns products — not a dead end.

## BORING BUT COMPLETE

Big image block · price + variant + date above the fold · rating near the title · returns in one sentence · scale shot · filters that work.

## PRETTY BUT EMPTY

Category pages with no filters. Titles that describe a mood instead of a product. Six near-identical photos and no scale shot. A size guide that opens a blurry PDF.

# The trust gap

Two shoppers, same page. One has bought from you before. The other has never heard of you, is on a phone, and is deciding in about four seconds whether your brand will actually ship.

## 19%

abandon because they don't trust the site with card details

## 13%

abandon over an unsatisfactory returns policy

Social proof is the cheapest fix available and chronically under-built by new brands. Vendor studies report large lifts from reviews and customer photos — treat the direction as real and the exact percentage as marketing. What is not in doubt: a product page with zero reviews and zero customer photos asks a stranger to go first.

### THE TRUST CHECKLIST FOR EVERY PRODUCT PAGE

- |                                                                       |                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> Review count and star rating near the title  | <input type="checkbox"/> Customer photos, not only studio shots       |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Delivery promise with a date, not “3–5 days” | <input type="checkbox"/> Return terms in one plain sentence           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> A scale reference — body, hand, known object | <input type="checkbox"/> A contact route a human answers              |
| <input type="checkbox"/> Payment logos at the point of payment        | <input type="checkbox"/> No unanswered question left to a footer link |

**Do this first:** email your last 50 delivered orders and ask for a photo review. A one-evening job that changes every product page you own.

# Two audiences, two different machines

|                       | Paid                          | Organic                         |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| What you buy          | Attention, immediately        | Attention, eventually           |
| Cost shape            | Rent. Stops when you stop.    | Build. Compounds if maintained. |
| Speed to first result | Days                          | Months                          |
| What it teaches you   | Which message converts, fast  | Which questions your market has |
| Biggest risk          | Cost rises faster than margin | You quit before it compounds    |

\$318

blended DTC acquisition cost, up 16.1% from \$274. A US figure — the direction is universal.

0.7% / 2.8%

organic social vs paid search conversion. Not competing numbers — different jobs.

The mistake is not choosing one. The mistake is running only the rented one while your acquisition cost climbs underneath you. Organic social creates the demand that search later captures.

**The operating rule:** paid buys this month's revenue and this month's learning. Organic buys next year's margin. A brand running only one is either fragile or slow.

# Search, in the AI era

48%

of queries now show an AI Overview

34–61%

reported drop in organic CTR when one appears

+632%

AI-referred traffic YoY, converting at 1.3%

Read that correctly. Search is not dying. The **informational** click is dying. The transactional and brand click is not.

WHAT D2C BRANDS SHOULD ACTUALLY BUILD

1. **Product and category pages that can rank.** Real titles, descriptions, specifications, size and material detail, FAQs on the page. Most D2C category pages have ~40 words and cannot rank for anything.

2. **Brand queries.** The searches that follow an ad or a Reel — “[brand] reviews”, “[brand] delivery time”. Own these or a marketplace listing will.

3. **Answer pages, not blog posts.** “How to know my ring size”, “will this tarnish”. Short, self-contained blocks under a clear question heading, written to be quoted.

4. **Being citable.** Clear claims, specific numbers, a real author, structured data. Citation is becoming the new ranking.

OLD SERP

Click goes to result 1

AI-ANSWER SERP

Often no click at all

# Social, platform by platform

The question is not “which platform should we be on” but “what job is each platform doing”. Posting the same asset everywhere is why most brand accounts flatline.

| Platform    | The job it does                                                                                      | The metric that matters               |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Instagram   | Discovery + aesthetic. Reels reach strangers, carousels get saved, Stories convert the already-warm. | Non-follower reach, saves, DMs        |
| Facebook    | Older buyers, community, resale of trust. Often quietly your best paid audience.                     | Referral traffic quality, not likes   |
| WhatsApp    | Not social media. Your owned one-to-one channel — see page 11.                                       | Opt-ins, reply rate, revenue          |
| Pinterest   | A search engine in a social costume. Long-lived, high-intent: home, fashion, jewelry, décor.         | Outbound clicks, saves over months    |
| YouTube     | Depth and objection-handling. Six honest minutes answer what a Reel cannot. Also a search engine.    | Watch time, then assisted conversions |
| Threads / X | Founder voice and speed. Cheap to test opinions and hooks before paying for them.                    | Replies, not impressions              |
| Snapchat    | Younger, regional. Test only when your buyer is genuinely there.                                     | Cost per swipe-up vs Meta             |

**WARNING 1**

Organic social converts at 0.7% — the lowest of any measured channel. Its job is demand creation. Do not judge it with a last-click report.

**WARNING 2**

Engagement benchmarks are near-useless across sources — the denominator changes and the “winning format” flips with it. Track your own trend.

**The bootstrap allocation:** one platform built properly beats six maintained badly. Pick where your buyer already searches; treat the rest as repost destinations.

# The channel most Indian D2C brands under-use

WhatsApp is not a social platform. It is the only channel where you own the relationship, the list and the delivery — no algorithm in between. Vendor-reported figures put open rates at 90%+ and cart recovery at 12–40% against email's 3–14%. Those are self-published numbers with no methodology: treat them as direction, not promise. The structure, though, is not in dispute — a message that lands in the same inbox as someone's family gets read.

**Order placed****Shipped****Delivered****Review request****Replenish**

## WHERE IT EARNS ITS KEEP

- Order and shipping updates — your highest-opened message, and the natural place to ask for a review
- Abandoned cart within 30 minutes; intent decays fast
- COD confirmation (page 17) — this one moves real money
- Back-in-stock and restock alerts
- Post-delivery check-in, where repeat purchase actually starts

## WHERE BRANDS RUIN IT

Broadcasting offers to everyone, twice a week, until people block the number. WhatsApp's power comes from being *expected*. Every message should be one the customer would have wanted anyway.

**Rule:** transactional first, conversational second, promotional last — and never more than the customer would tolerate from a person.

# What you are actually buying

Paid does one thing: it rents attention from people who did not ask for you. Everything after the click — add to cart, buy, come back — is your store's job, not the platform's. US-dollar reference points below; Indian CPMs run far lower, so use the structure, not the absolutes.

META ECOMMERCE  
**1.9× ROAS**  
CPM ~\$14–15 · CTR ~2.19%

GOOGLE PMAX  
**4.8× ROAS**  
\$0.82 CPC · Shopping ~\$0.66

STRONGEST PAID CHANNEL  
**2.8% CVR**  
paid search, all channels measured

The number that governs your account is not a benchmark. It is your breakeven ROAS.

BREAKEVEN ROAS  
**1 ÷ gross margin**

| Gross margin | Gross breakeven ROAS | At 30% RTO, true breakeven |
|--------------|----------------------|----------------------------|
| 50%          | 2.0                  | 2.9                        |
| 40%          | 2.5                  | 3.6                        |
| 30%          | 3.3                  | 4.8                        |

A brand celebrating 2.2 ROAS at 40% margin with 25% RTO is losing money on every order and calling it growth.

Meta / Instagram — interruption; you create demand, creative does the work.

Google Search & Shopping — harvest; demand exists, you compete on relevance and price.

TikTok — entertainment-led discovery; ads that look like ads are ignored.

YouTube — consideration and objection-handling at scale.

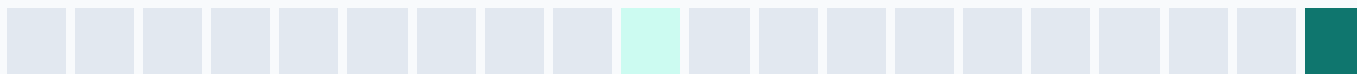
**Sequencing for a bootstrapped brand:** harvest existing demand first — Search, Shopping, brand terms — then pay to create new demand.

# Creative is the ad account

# 4–8%

of Meta creatives become winners, across a dataset of 550,000+ ads.  
Motion Creative Benchmarks 2026

Read that as a production requirement, not a discouragement. If one in twenty creatives wins, shipping four ads a month finds a winner about twice a year. That is not an algorithm problem — it is a volume problem. Reported fatigue windows have compressed to **2–3 weeks** on video-heavy placements. Winners expire; the account needs a queue behind them.



Twenty creatives shipped. One winner, one near-miss. That ratio is the plan, not the accident.

## A WORKING CREATIVE SYSTEM

1. **A hook library, not an ad library.** Write 20 opening lines before you shoot. The first 3 seconds decide the other 30.
2. **One product, many angles.** Problem, proof, price, objection, occasion, comparison, founder story, customer voice — eight ads from one shoot.
3. **Test hooks before production.** Post them organically; the one that stops the scroll for free will stop it for money.
4. **Iterate winners, retire losers on schedule.** Four to six variations per winner; an expiry date written the day it launches.
5. **Keep a swipe file of your own winners.** What worked in March is the brief for September.

**The diagnostic:** if CTR is fine but add-to-cart is not, the ad wrote a cheque the product page cannot cash. That is the next page.

# The ad works. Nobody adds to cart.

Reported add-to-cart rates cluster at **4–8% of sessions**, and under ~5% is widely treated as a product-page problem rather than a traffic problem. The absolute number matters less than the diagnosis — benchmarks vary enormously by category.

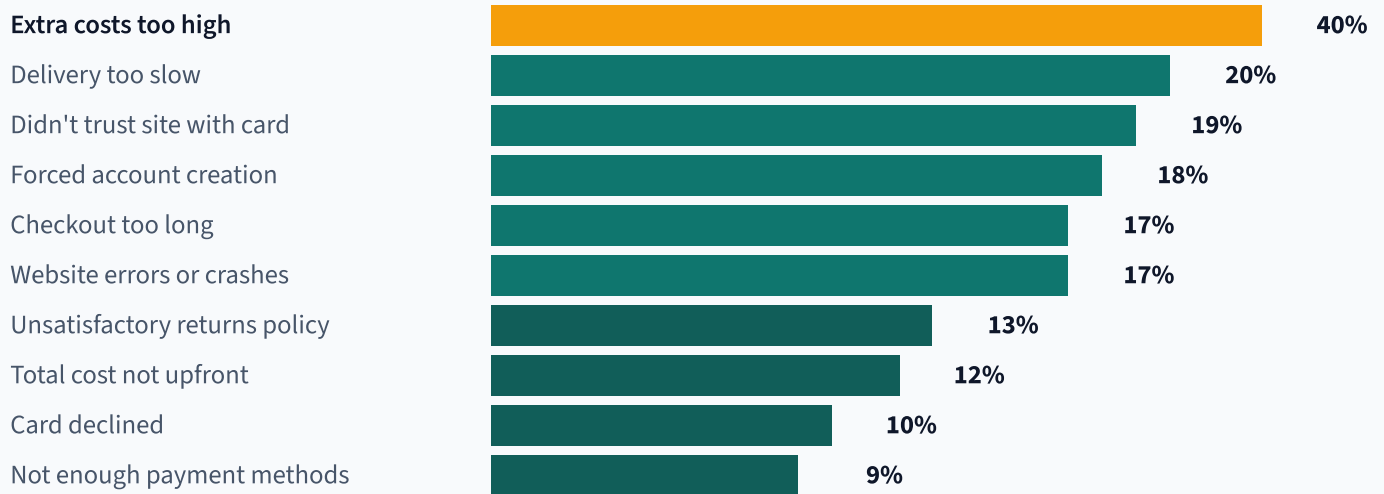
- 1 Did the page match the ad?** The most common cause by far. Dedicated landing pages are reported to convert around **4.0% vs 2.35%** for general site pages. Send the click to the exact thing it was promised.
- 2 Did the page load before they left?** Check bounce rate for paid mobile traffic specifically. Far above site average = a speed problem in a creative costume.
- 3 Is the price a surprise?** If the ad implied a price band the page breaks, add-to-cart collapses — and it is invisible in dashboards.
- 4 Can they tell what it actually is?** Size, material, scale, fit, how it looks on a real person. Missing scale information kills more carts than any other content gap.
- 5 Is there a reason to act now?** Not fake urgency — a delivery date, genuine low stock, a bundle that makes sense.
- 6 Is the button where a thumb is?** On a phone, above the fold, without a scroll hunt.

**The test that settles it:** run the same traffic to a purpose-built landing page for two weeks. If ATC jumps, it was the page. If it doesn't, it was the audience or the offer.

# 70.22%

of carts are abandoned, averaged across 50 studies. Here are the actual reasons, after removing the 42% who were only browsing.

Baymard Institute



The top reason is not price. It is **surprise** — costs that appeared after the customer had already decided.

#### FIXES, RANKED BY THE SIZE OF THE LEAK THEY CLOSE

1. **Show the full cost early.** Shipping on the product page; a free-shipping threshold stated before the cart.
2. **Kill forced account creation.** Guest checkout, account offered after the order.
3. **Show a delivery date,** not a range of days.
4. **Cut fields.** Every removed field is recovered revenue.
5. **Put the returns policy in the checkout,** in one sentence.
6. **Add the payment options** your market defaults to.
7. **Fix the errors.** 17% is an engineering bug, not a marketing problem. Test on a real phone, on mobile data, monthly.

Baymard's estimate for fixing checkout usability alone: +35.26% conversion.

# If half of them started paying and stopped

## 47%

Checkout completion is commonly reported near 47%, improving with single-page checkouts. Cart abandonment and checkout abandonment are different metrics — conflating them hides the real problem.

Checkout abandonment counts only people who *started* checkout and left: a much warmer group, and a much more fixable one. If half the people who started paying you did not finish, the failure is mechanical, not persuasive.

### THE MECHANICAL CHECKLIST

- ☐ Complete a real purchase on a real phone on mobile data. Monthly. Personally.
- ☐ Test every payment method you offer — including the ones you assume work.
- ☐ Check payment failure rate with your gateway. A silent decline rate is pure lost revenue.
- ☐ Offer the payment methods your market actually defaults to.
- ☐ Auto-fill what you can; never ask twice for the same information.
- ☐ Make the coupon field small. A prominent empty coupon box sends people to a discount-hunting tab they never return from.
- ☐ Recover abandoned checkouts within 30 minutes, on the channel they actually read.

**On discounts:** a discount at checkout fixes an abandonment problem the way a painkiller fixes a fracture. If your checkout only completes with a code, the code is now your price. Fix the reason instead.

# RTO

A delivered order and a shipped order are not the same thing, and most D2C P&Ls are built on the wrong one. From 6,000+ Indian D2C brands and 410 million shipments in FY26:

**58%**

festive-quarter COD returns (prepaid: under 15%)

**21–39%**

brand-level RTO range by March 2026

**21%**

where the brands that fixed it landed — operations, not ads

**66%**

of incremental volume from Tier 2–3, where COD is highest

Every RTO order costs shipping both ways, packaging, handling and the product's time out of inventory — with zero revenue against it. Widely reported estimates put the hit at ₹150–300 per order. A brand at 30% RTO is running a different business from the one its ROAS dashboard describes.

## THE FIXES, IN ORDER OF IMPACT

1. **Confirm every COD order** — WhatsApp or a call, within the hour. The highest-return operational change available to an Indian D2C brand.
2. **Make prepaid attractive.** A small prepaid discount usually costs less than the RTO it prevents. Do the arithmetic for your own AOV.
3. **Flag risky orders** — repeat RTO pincodes, repeat refusers, addresses that fail verification.
4. **Work NDR the same day.** Most failed attempts are recoverable within 24 hours.
5. **Communicate through delivery.** A customer who knows the parcel is coming accepts it.

100 ORDERS, AS REPORTED

**2.5× ROAS = fine**

SAME 100 ORDERS, AFTER 30% RTO

**2.5× ROAS = a loss**

True breakeven =  $1 \div (\text{gross margin} \times \text{delivered rate})$ , minus fees.

# The inventory you cannot see

20.8%

of online orders come back overall — US online apparel measured at 24.4%. Causes are fit, colour and material expectation.

\$1.7T

estimated global cost of inventory distortion — ~6.2% of retail sales, about two-thirds of it stockouts.

Returns are a **content problem before they are a logistics problem**. Better scale shots, honest colour, measured dimensions and specific size guidance cut returns more cheaply than any reverse-logistics deal.

|                  | Stockout                                                    | Overstock                                  |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| What you lose    | The sale, the ad spend that produced it, often the customer | Cash, locked up, for months                |
| What it hides as | “A slow month”                                              | “Healthy inventory”                        |
| The real cost    | You paid for the click and sent them to a competitor        | Working capital you cannot spend on growth |

MINIMUM VIABLE INVENTORY DISCIPLINE

- Know your **days of cover** per SKU, updated weekly. Not total stock — days.
- Set a reorder point that includes lead time, not a gut feeling.
- **Never advertise a SKU you cannot ship** for the campaign's full duration. Paid traffic to an out-of-stock product is the most expensive mistake in the book.
- Track the difference between units sold and units delivered. That gap is your real demand signal.
- Decide markdown rules *before* you need them, while you can still think clearly.

# Retention

Everything so far improves the first purchase. This page decides whether the business compounds.

## 2.9% vs 1.7%

returning vs new visitor conversion — and return visits are 52.8% of all traffic.

## \$318, +16.1%

blended DTC acquisition cost. Acquisition gets more expensive every year. Retention does not.

### OWNED CHANNELS ARE MIS-WEIGHTED BY MOST BRANDS

## 41%

of email revenue comes from flows — just 5.3% of sends. Roughly 18× the revenue per recipient of campaigns.

## 45.2%

of SMS revenue comes from flows, at 7.6% of sends.

## 48%

of flow-driven email revenue comes from new buyers — flows close first purchases too.

Translation: the automated messages you set up once outperform the campaigns you agonise over weekly. A brand whose second-purchase rate is climbing survives a rising CAC; a brand at a 15% repeat rate cannot.

### THE EIGHT FLOWS THAT MATTER, IN BUILD ORDER

1 Abandoned checkout — fire within 30 minutes

2 Abandoned cart

3 Browse abandonment

4 Welcome / first-purchase nurture

5 Order and shipping updates

6 Post-delivery review request

7 Replenishment / next-best-product

8 Win-back when your data says they've gone quiet

**Build these once.** They run while you sleep, for every customer your ads bought. Sources: Contentsquare 2026; Shopify 2026; Klaviyo 2026 benchmarks.

# The first 30 days

Do not fix eleven things. Fix the first one that is broken.

## WEEK 1

Measure. No changes.

- Fill in the page 4 scorecard. Split every metric by mobile and desktop.
- Complete one real purchase on your own store, on a phone, on mobile data.
- Pull your last 90 days of RTO and returns, by payment method.

## WEEK 2

Fix the mechanics.

- Page speed on product and cart pages.
- Guest checkout on. Fields cut. Shipping cost shown before the cart.
- Every payment method tested end to end.

## WEEK 3

Fix the page.

- Reviews and customer photos on your top 5 revenue products.
- Delivery date, returns policy and scale reference on every product page.
- Point paid traffic to the exact product advertised.

## WEEK 4

Fix the leaks after the sale.

- COD confirmation on WhatsApp within the hour.
- First four flows live: abandoned checkout, abandoned cart, shipping updates, review request.
- Re-measure the scorecard. Compare. Write down what moved.

**Then repeat.** Every quarter, top to bottom. The leak map does not change. Your numbers do.

You are not one campaign away. You are one honest measurement away from knowing which fix is worth making.

# Sources and method

Every figure in this book is traceable. Where a number comes from a vendor blog rather than a disclosed dataset, it is presented as a *reported range*, not a fact.

## DIRECTLY VERIFIED, PRIMARY SOURCES

- Baymard Institute — cart abandonment rate (70.22%, average of 50 studies) and abandonment reasons
- Baymard Institute — Mobile UX Benchmark 2026 (71,000+ elements reviewed)
- Contentsquare — 2026 Digital Experience Benchmark (99 billion sessions, 6,000+ sites, Q4 2024–Q4 2025)
- Unicommerce — India D2C Report 2026 (6,000+ brands, 410 million shipments, FY26)
- Klaviyo — 2026 Email and SMS Marketing Benchmarks
- Littledata — Shopify conversion benchmarks (2,800 stores; benchmarked 2023)

## NAMED DATASETS CITED VIA SECONDARY REPORTING

- Motion — Creative Benchmarks 2026 (550,000+ ads)
- Shopify — Global Commerce Report 2026 (CAC \$318)
- Google × Deloitte — Milliseconds Make Millions (2020)
- smec — Google Ads Ecommerce Benchmarks Q1 2026
- Coresight / NRF — return-rate data · Retail Insight Network / IHL — inventory distortion

## PRESENTED AS REPORTED RANGES ONLY

Add-to-cart rates · checkout completion · site-search lift · UGC conversion lift · AI Overview click-through impact · WhatsApp open and recovery rates · repeat-purchase rates · India RTO percentages · landing-page conversion comparisons.